

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Dirk Rice, a farmer in Philo who has adopted conservation practices, pulls a weed as he inspects soybean plants. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Midwest’s ‘silent killer’ worries crop experts

Conservation practices are needed to protect Illinois farmers, they say, as topsoil loss increases and the federal government cuts back on initiatives

By **Brandon Chew**
Chicago Tribune

As the deadline approaches for Congress to renew the U.S. Farm Bill, agricultural experts and farmers are calling on legislators to prioritize protecting topsoil in the Midwest and throughout the country, especially as the federal

government is withdrawing from conservation initiatives.

Topsoil is eroding, on average, at a rate of three-quarters of an inch per year in the Midwest, a rate double what the U.S. Department of Agriculture considers sustainable, according to a 2022 study published in the journal Earth’s Future. The study also

concluded more than 57 billion metric tons of topsoil have eroded in the Midwest over the last 160 years.

“Not to sound alarmist, but we rely and a lot of the world relies on the Midwest producing a lot of food,” said Evan Thaler, a geological researcher who helped author the study. “Fertilizing crops can’t keep up with the amount of productivity that’s lost by erosion.”

Topsoil contains living microorganisms and decaying plant roots that are important for productive crop growth. Excessive topsoil erosion can lead to a decrease in

soil fertility levels and a decline in potential crop yields.

No-till and reduced tillage farming, as well as cover crops, are among the best ways to counter topsoil erosion, experts say, especially as climate change has led to increased rainfall intensity. But under the Trump administration, federal support for these practices could be dramatically reduced.

Some experts, including Andrew Margenot, an associate professor of crop sciences at the University of Illinois, have expressed skepticism about the

Turn to Topsoil, Page 5

Rate hike prompts calls for action

Legislators pressured after State Farm’s 27.2% increase for Illinois homeowners

By **Jeremy Gorner**
and **Lizzie Kane**
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker wasted no time in calling on state legislators to do something about rising insurance rates after State Farm announced it was hiking homeowners insurance by 27.2% beginning this month, citing rising costs due to extreme weather events and pricier repairs.

“Enact a legislative solution during the veto session that prevents insurance companies from taking advantage of consumers through severe and unnecessary rate hikes, such as those proposed by State Farm,” Pritzker said in a social media post.

The governor’s angry words were met with a quick rebuttal from the Bloomington, Illinois-based insurer and state business interests, but other officials were just as quick to join in the politically popular call to hold down costs.

“I do agree with the governor that what State Farm did is wrong and they need to fix it,” House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch, a Democrat from Hillside, told the Tribune. “If they don’t, as a leader in this state, as a leader of one of our chambers, we’re going to take a look at it because we have to protect our consumers.”

Right now in Illinois, there’s no effective mechanism to prevent companies like State Farm from imposing rates for home and auto insurance that are deemed to be excessive,

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Trump trade policies upset retailers’ plans

Tariff threats create uncertainty as holiday orders are arranged

By **Anne D’Innocenzo**
and **Mae Anderson**
Associated Press

NEW YORK — With summer in full swing, retail executives are sweating a different season.

It’s less than 22 weeks until Christmas, a time when businesses that make and sell consumer goods usually nail down their holiday orders and prices.

But President Donald Trump’s vacillating trade policies, part of his effort to revive the nation’s diminished manufacturing base and to reduce the U.S. deficit in exported goods, have complicated those end-of-year plans.

Balsam Hill, which sells artificial trees and other decorations online, expects to publish

fewer and thinner holiday catalogs because the products keep changing with the tariff — import tax — rates the president sets, postpones and revises.

“The uncertainty has led us to spend all our time trying to rejigger what we’re ordering, where we’re bringing it in, when it’s going to get here,” said Mac Harman, CEO of Balsam Hill parent company Balsam Brands. “We don’t know which items we’re going to have to put in the catalog or not.”

Months of confusion over which countries’ products may become more expensive to import has left a question mark over the holiday shopping season. U.S. retailers often begin planning for the winter holidays in January and typically finalize the bulk of their orders by the end of June. The seesawing tariffs already have factored into their calculations.

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People in handcuffs are escorted by federal agents to vans parked outside the Intensive Supervision Appearance Program office run by ICE in Chicago’s South Loop on June 4. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Data reveals Chicago-area surge in ICE arrests under Trump

9-fold increase seen in detentions of those without criminal past

By **Joe Mahr**
and **Nell Salzman**
Chicago Tribune

With the Trump administration pushing far more aggressive immigration enforcement across the country and in Chicago, a Tribune analysis of newly released data shows a significant increase in the number of immigrants detained

in the Chicago area — particularly those with no known criminal background.

The findings come from a Tribune analysis of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement data obtained and shared by the research group Deportation Data Project. The analysis shows that, as President Donald Trump’s administration has pushed enforcement in sanctuary cities such as Chicago, ICE saw notable spikes in the number of people initially detained at two ICE processing centers in the area.

The figures peaked at 88 bookings on an early June day that, at the time, drew attention for clashes between Chicago community members and federal immigration agents. Of the 88 booked that day, the latest analysis found, three-fourths had no criminal record logged by ICE.

The surge in detentions — including immigrants with no known criminal record — mirrors broader trends across the country. The second Trump administration

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